

Indus Valley Civilization: Sites, Urban Culture & Decline

Complete study notes on Harappan sites, town planning, crafts, Meluhha trade, society, religion debates and multi-causal decline - with Vedic contrast.

Portion focus ~68% · Topic: hist-ancient

PYQ themes: IVC sites & features · Harappan crafts & trade · Decline theories · Urban planning

Why this portion (PYQ lens)

Hottest Ancient India sub-portion in this hub (~68% portion chance). Site-feature matching recurs across 2016-2025; parent hist-ancient is lower overall, but this slice punches above its weight.

Years appeared (synthesis): 2016, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2024, 2025

Why UPSC asks this

Distinctive archaeological signatures (dockyard, Great Bath, ploughed field, reservoirs) create clean matching and multi-statement MCQs without dynastic lists. UPSC also tests whether you confuse Harappan urbanism with early Vedic society and whether you treat decline as a single invasion story.

Chronology and geographic span

In standard Indian exam framing, the Indus (Harappan) civilisation is a Bronze Age urban culture of the greater Indus system, with Early, Mature and Late phases. The Mature Harappan phase is the urban peak Prelims emphasises: planned towns, seals, standardised weights, and craft-trade networks.

Geographically the culture stretches from the Pakistani Indus plains (Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Chanhudaro) into Gujarat (Lothal, Dholavira, Surkotada), Rajasthan (Kalibangan), Haryana (Rakhigarhi, Banawali) and an eastern fringe marker such as Alamgirpur on the Hindon. Thinking in clusters - Sindh/Punjab type-sites, Gujarat maritime and water sites, Rajasthan-Haryana inland sites - speeds up map and matching questions.

Town planning and civic technology

Mature Harappan towns typically show an approximate street grid, baked bricks of recurring ratios, and elaborate drainage: covered drains, soak arrangements, and house connections treated in textbooks as civic hygiene planning. Many sites present a bipartite layout - an elevated citadel with public, elite or ritual structures and a lower town of houses and workshops.

Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath is the classic public water structure. Harappa is remembered for granary or warehouse complexes. Uniform weights and modular bricks imply coordination across distant settlements even though the script is unread. If a statement claims Harappans lacked urban civic sense, drains and planning are the elimination tools.

Site-feature bank (exam gold)

Matching lists are won by uniqueness. Lothal's dockyard is the near-unique maritime anchor; also link Lothal to bead manufacture and warehouses. Dholavira stands out for reservoirs, a three-part city division and a large signboard with Indus signs. Kalibangan supplies ploughed-field evidence and fire altars. Mohenjo-daro owns the Great Bath; Harappa owns granaries in the usual row sets; Rakhigarhi signals settlement scale within India; Chanhudaro signals craft (especially beads) and is often noted without a typical citadel.

Treat Surkotada horse evidence as contested - useful for trap awareness, dangerous as dogma. Alamgirpur marks eastern cultural reach. When four sites and four features appear, eliminate by the most distinctive pair first.

Economy, crafts and Meluhha trade

Agriculture underpinned cities: wheat and barley are the usual staples, with regional crop mixes and a pastoral component (cattle, sheep/goat). Craft specialisation is a PYQ magnet - steatite seals, bead-making (Lothal, Chanhudaro), shell working, and copper/bronze metallurgy. Standardised weights support regulated exchange.

Long-distance links matter. Mesopotamian texts refer to Meluhha, commonly associated in exam literature with the Indus world; Gujarat's Lothal anchors the maritime narrative toward the Persian Gulf. Beads, metals, shell and timber appear in typical interaction-sphere summaries. Seals and sealings suggest identity and accounting functions. Without a deciphered script, labels like 'empire' stay inferential - prefer craft, trade and planning language.

Agriculture, animals and everyday life

Cities rested on an agrarian and pastoral base. Wheat and barley dominate the usual crop list; sesame, pulses and other regional crops appear in broader archaeological summaries. Irrigation and floodplain farming logics are inferred from settlement location along rivers and from water works at sites such as Dholavira rather than from a single readable farm manual.

Animal economy typically includes cattle, sheep and goat; buffalo and other species appear in site reports. Horse evidence is uneven and contested (Surkotada is the usual exam flashpoint) - state the debate, do not invent certainty. Everyday life markers include craft debris, weights, seals, toys and household drainage connections. These material cues matter more for Prelims than speculative palace chronicles.

Society, seals, script and religion

The Indus script remains undeciphered. Seals frequently show animal motifs; the so-called unicorn and other creatures recur. Figurines labelled mother goddess and Pashupati-type images are attested objects, but reading them as full Vedic religion is interpretive - overconfident theology loses marks.

Craft quarters, differential house sizes and public structures suggest social complexity, yet named kings and readable law codes are absent. Exam discipline: separate what is excavated from what is imagined. Prefer statements about planning, crafts, trade and site features over romantic Harappan Vedism.

Decline theories - multi-causal, not dogma

Mature urbanism fades into Late Harappan patterns rather than an overnight collapse. Serious prep treats decline as multi-causal: aridification and climate stress, river-course shifts (including Ghaggar-Hakra debates), ecological strain around dense settlements, and disruption of long-distance trade. Factors combine differently by region.

Single-cause Aryan invasion as the only explanation is outdated for exam purposes. Separate decline of cities from disappearance of people: regional and rural continuities matter. In assertion-reason items, prefer options that allow multiple pressures over absolute monocausal claims.

For revision, keep a three-bucket card: (1) climate/aridity, (2) rivers and ecology, (3) trade and urban institutional stress. Any option that forbids all but one bucket is suspicious unless the stem forces a single best answer.

Contrast with early Vedic society

A recurring trap equates Indus urban culture with early Vedic society. Textbook contrasts emphasise Harappan planned towns, crafts and seals versus early Vedic pastoral-agrarian life with different ritual and textual profiles. Chronology and material culture do not collapse into one identity. Use this contrast when options smuggle horse sacrifice, Vedic gods, or purely pastoral economics into Mature Harappan statements without evidence.

Civilisations can influence later cultures without being identical to them. Precision beats nostalgia.

How questions usually look

Expect site-feature matching lists; multi-statement sets on drains, bricks, script, trade or decline; assertion-reason items that attach a true fact to a false cause; and IVC-versus-Vedic mix-ups. Tactic: lock distinctive pairs first, then test absolute words (always, only, never), then check whether religion or decline claims outrun the evidence.

Major sites and distinctive features

Site | Region | Distinctive feature(s)

Harappa -- Punjab (Pakistan) -- Granaries / warehouses; Cemetery H
Mohenjo-daro -- Sindh (Pakistan) -- Great Bath; citadel-lower town
Lothal -- Gujarat -- Dockyard; bead factory; warehouse
Dholavira -- Kutch, Gujarat -- Reservoirs; three-part city; signboard
Kalibangan -- Rajasthan -- Ploughed field; fire altars
Rakhigarhi -- Haryana -- Very large settlement scale in India
Chanhudaro -- Sindh -- Bead-making / craft specialisation
Surkotada -- Gujarat -- Horse-remains debate (contested)
Alamgirpur -- Uttar Pradesh -- Eastern fringe of Harappan culture
Banawali -- Haryana -- Fortified Harappan traits

IVC vs early Vedic - exam contrast

Theme | Mature Harappan | Early Vedic (textbook contrast)

Settlement -- Planned towns, craft quarters -- Pastoral-agrarian; limited urbanism
Economy cue -- Craft + long-distance trade + agri -- Cattle wealth emphasis; pastoral mix
Script / texts -- Undeciphered seals/signs -- Later textual corpus (different profile)
Ritual evidence -- Interpretive (figurines, some altars) -- Fire sacrifice / hymn centred in texts
Political image -- No named kings in readable texts -- Tribal/chiefly polities in early layers

Map / list facts

- Harappa (Punjab, Pakistan) - granary complexes, Cemetery H; type-site of the culture
- Mohenjo-daro (Sindh, Pakistan) - Great Bath, citadel and lower town
- Dholavira (Kutch, Gujarat) - reservoirs, three-part city plan, large signboard with Indus signs
- Lothal (Gujarat) - dockyard, bead factory, warehouse; Persian Gulf trade narrative
- Kalibangan (Rajasthan) - ploughed field evidence, fire altars
- Rakhigarhi (Haryana) - among the largest Harappan settlements in India
- Chanhudaro (Sindh) - craft centre, especially bead-making; often without a citadel
- Surkotada (Gujarat) - cited in horse-remains debates (contested, not settled)
- Banawali (Haryana) - fortified Harappan settlement traits
- Alamgirpur (UP, Hindon) - eastern cultural fringe toward the doab margin

Common traps

- x Treating IVC and early Vedic society as the same civilisation under two names
- x Explaining urban decline by a single invasion as the only cause
- x Assigning the dockyard to any site other than Lothal
- x Claiming the Indus script has been conclusively deciphered
- x Reading mother-goddess figurines or Pashupati-type seals as proven Vedic religion
- x Saying Harappans lacked civic planning because texts are absent
- x Collapsing decline of cities into disappearance of all people

Must remember

- Mature Harappan towns: approximate grid streets, baked bricks, covered drains, citadel vs lower town
- Lothal = dockyard; Dholavira = water / three-part plan / signboard; Kalibangan = ploughed field (+ fire altars); Mohenjo-daro = Great Bath; Harappa = granaries; Rakhigarhi = scale in India; Chanhudaro = bead craft
- Script remains undeciphered; seals with animal motifs including the so-called unicorn
- Standardised weights and brick ratios signal coordination across a wide cultural zone
- Meluhha in Mesopotamian texts is commonly linked to the Indus; long-distance craft and maritime trade
- Decline is multi-causal (climate, river shifts, trade disruption, ecology) - not invasion-only dogma
- Do not equate IVC with early Vedic culture: different urban profile, ritual evidence, chronology emphasis

Quick revision checklist

- [] Redraw site-feature table from memory (8+ sites)
- [] List five urban traits (bricks, drains, grid, citadel-lower town, weights)
- [] State Meluhha trade idea in one sentence
- [] Give three decline factors (not invasion-only)
- [] Write two IVC vs early Vedic contrast points

Educational prioritisation heuristic - not an official UPSC prediction. (c) UPSC IAS Study Hub original notes.